Find the moment. Cut before the answer.

PROBLEM 01

20–60s

A practical shortlisting tool for cold-audience microdrama ads.

50	64	295/295	56
episodes analyzed	promos shortlisted	source checks passed	automated tests passing

01 Solve the editor’s decision

Editors need usable moments and exact cut points, not another episode summary. I chose Problem 1 because safe edit boundaries are computational, while betrayal, clarity and unresolved tension need editorial judgment.

Assumptions: source timestamps are authoritative; duration is inclusive at 20–60s; dialogue stays whole; mashups use two segments. Some episodes have no suitable cut. No video, campaign data or exhaustive-recall guarantee is assumed.

02 Code protects the cut. AI critiques the story.

CODE
PARSE
Timed source slices

→

CODE
RETRIEVE
Safe promo windows

→

OPTIONAL AI
JUDGE
8 finalists by default

→

CODE
VALIDATE
Every output boundary

→

EDITOR
POST
Approve the exact cut

CODE · deterministic rules

3,727 beats become 4,915 audiovisual slices. Retrieve windows, preserve source boundaries, reject mid-dialogue edits and audit every output.

AI · swappable critique

Gemini, OpenAI or Anthropic judges up to eight finalists by default. Keys and model IDs are editable. Scores are labeled by origin; AI cannot move timestamps.

EDITOR · final approval

Check actual first-3s onset, standalone human stakes and the unresolved ending. Review long beats and mashup causality in footage before posting.

03 Five signals, one transparent score

Hook 30%	Cliffhanger 30%	Clarity 20%	Heat 10%	Pace 10%

Composite rank and posting priority are separate. Clear continuous cuts precede uncertain openings and unverified trailer bridges. Saved results use heuristics; live AI critiques only the configured shortlist.

04 Scale the filtering, then spend on finalists

$0 API fees for the saved offline run

Recorded scoring/audit time: 0.71s locally. Eight finalists, in batches of four, bound live inference. Two batches at an assumed 8s add ~16s; live latency is unmeasured.

Worked example: 14,400 input + 1,280 output tokens at historical $0.30/$2.50 per million = **$0.00752/show**, ~$1.50 for 200 weekly shows. This is an editable scenario, not a current-model quote or invoice; hosting, retries and editor time are separate.

The actual input is ~67.8k estimated tokens. A three-pass premium scenario at $2.50/$10 per million with 10k output tokens costs ~$0.61. Scale through independent show workers, input/model-version caches and rate limits. A sliding 60s boundary index would replace the current boundary-pair enumeration and repeated beat scans.

Post the conflict. Cut before the payoff.

An editor’s playbook, with the weak picks left visible.

05 Actual posting order + one test challenger

POST 01 35.2s · 85.1/100

The stolen wedding

E1 00:39.10–01:14.30

OPENING EVIDENCE · ABRIDGED

Because he is marrying me.

UNRESOLVED CUT

How long?

POST 02 28.5s · 80.6/100

The protective stranger

E3 01:24.00–01:52.50

OPENING EVIDENCE · ABRIDGED

The Bearded Stranger effortlessly blocks the guard's strike and drives a devastating strike into him, dropping the armed gua…

UNRESOLVED CUT

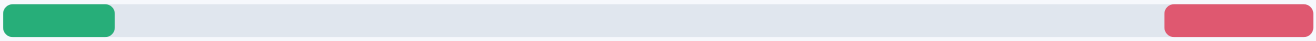
Why are you doing this?

POST 03 · E3 00:08.80–00:40.40 · 31.6s · “You stole my wedding” → “And what happens to me?”
CHALLENGER · E25 00:13.20–00:33.80 · 20.6s · Painful shoulder grab / wound reveal → “Who?”

Source evidence is abridged. Test reviewed variants with equal spend; compare 3s hold, click-through and downstream starts. No lift has been measured.

06 The cut is inspectable

OPENING · FIRST 3s CLIFFHANGER · LAST 4s



E1 · 00:39.10 E1 · 01:14.30

35.20s total · 1 source segment(s) · edit boundaries preserved

First recommendation: E1 00:39.10–01:14.30. Color marks review windows, not additional edits. Exact source cut points are retained.

07 Real failures, concrete corrections

Actual source case	Bad decision	Correction
E30 · 00:03.00–00:43.50	A pocket-watch “chain” scored as physical conflict.	**Reject the false hook.**
E49 · 01:24.00–01:52.80	Eyes “burning” with ambition looked like an injury.	**Exclude metaphorical heat.**
E21 · 00:47.30–01:39.20	The child recovers before a Duchess subplot question.	**Reject the resolved arc.**

11 curated regressions are not an accuracy benchmark. E22: SFX ends 00:42.80 vs scene 00:42.50; the real timestamp is retained and flagged.

AI tools used · one actual mistake

Codex assisted code, rubric design, testing and docs. An early rule matched “hang” inside “cliffhanger,” promoting a calm cello ending in E16 00:59.00–01:23.19. Source inspection, word boundaries and regression tests corrected it.

Rerun it in the interview

Use the original synthetic sample or upload TXT/ZIP files. Select episodes (e.g. 2, 5, 8–10), choose a model/key, test the API and rerun. HTTP 503 gets bounded retries; exhausted requests remain visibly unsuccessful.

295/295 emitted candidates source-valid **56** tests in a clean pinned setup Saved run: **offline**

Limits: long-beat onset, rhetorical questions and mashup causality need review. No footage, ad-lift or successful live inference verified; provider contracts use mocks.

Prototype / code · Unedited outputs · Google pricing reference